

By Anthony Fenech
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MINNEAPOLIS – In the air, heading home from my third season on the Tigers' beat. It began with sunny skies in early February and ended with a steady rain on Sunday afternoon. Such was the story of the 2017 Tigers, a team that headed into spring training with World Series aspirations and in just six months, were stripped of its parts, looking firmly towards the future.

But that's not what I'll remember about this season. Here are the behind-the-scenes moments through a beat reporter's eye that I will:

- Finding about late owner Mike Ilitch's death while an Amtrak train from New York City slowed to a stop in Washington, D.C. around 6 p.m. on Feb. XX. What followed was a four-hour scramble inside Union Station. The Sbarro pizzeria employees let me stay while they cleaned up, which I thought was cool.

- A long pause during a call that night with baseball agent Scott Boras. I thought the call had dropped. It hadn't. Boras was choked up talking about Ilitch. Yes, Boras has a job to do – part of which is get getting his players the most money possible. But he had a special relationship with Ilitch and loved what he stood for.

- Sitting on a golf cart, making eye contact with Hall of Fame pitcher Pedro Martinez after a spring training game. Martinez was my favorite player growing up. For whatever reason, he walked over and shook my hand.

- Jim Leyland's postgame press conference after the United States nail-biting victory over Colombia in the opening round of the World Baseball Classic in Miami. He sat down and immediately said, "Now you know why I'm not managing anymore."

- The electricity of the crowd of the Dominican Republic-U.S. match-up. Covering the WBC changed my mind about the event but it needs a better timing.

- Taking a picture of manager Brad Ausmus and my mom. She had bugged me for two seasons about getting a picture with Ausmus and after one spring game, he obliged to my uncomfortable request. She sent it to her friends.

- Francisco Rodriguez, slumped in a chair, speechless after blowing a save against the Athletics in early May. The next day, it happened again. It was the scene of a pitcher who knew he didn't have it anymore.

- Rodriguez showing me his Baseball-Reference page after a game in Kansas City later in the season. No words offended him more than "mop-up."

- The friendship of Justin Upton and Ian Kinsler. Upton matured as a player in his two years with the Tigers. It was clear that Kinsler's everyday influence made him a better player. They talked baseball a lot.

- Walking into the visiting clubhouse at Comerica Park after an appearance on MLB Network and hearing Royals third baseman Mike Moustakas say, "Hey, there's the guy that said we're beatable." I loved the way that group of Royals played the game.

- Watching a documentary about Ukraine's fight for freedom in the visiting clubhouse at Kauffman Stadium. Many of the Tigers' Venezuelan players were watching intently. After more than a half hour, Kinsler offered a chair, a coffee and a towel. Unsure what to do, I sat down.

- Miguel Cabrera asking if the Tigers were going to trade him next. I was honest and said, "If you ever start hitting again" and it made him laugh, because he knows he's still one of the best hitters in baseball when healthy.
- The rounds of batting practice Victor Martinez would throw to his son, Victor Jose, before games. One afternoon at Progressive Field, standing in shallow centerfield, Victor Jose hit one over the high wall in left-centerfield. Only 13 years old, he claims he can hit a baseball over 300 feet. They were pure father and son moments.
- Talking about the solar eclipse with Justin Verlander. I did not know the former Tigers' ace was interested in astronomy, and I found it interesting.
- A text message received at 12:02 a.m. on Friday, Sept. 1.
- A conversation with catcher James McCann outside the Tigers clubhouse, a sign of leadership. If Kinsler is traded this off-season as expected, McCann becomes the team's leader and said after Sunday's regular season finale he is ready for that role.
- Nick Castellanos walking up the dugout steps to greet Daniel Norris when he was pulled from his second-to-last start of the season, another sign of leadership. Like McCann, Castellanos' presence will be elevated. The two have been afforded the opportunity to spread their wings.

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- Standing in front of Ian Kinsler's locker in mid-August, listening to him unload on umpire Angel Hernandez without my recorder on, hoping MLB.com reporter Jason Beck had his on. The conversation seemed as off-the-record as they come, . One thing about Kinsler: He is very aware. He knows what
- J.D. trade
- The game in Seattle when you knew it was over